

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Mostly sunny 73/52 • Tomorrow: Mostly sunny 65/48 **B22**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 21, 2025 • \$4

Officials undercut president on strikes

Targeted sea route is not ordinarily used to traffic fentanyl to U.S., they say

BY **TERRENCE MCCOY,**
ANA VANESSA HERRERO
AND **SAMANTHA SCHMIDT**

MEXICO CITY — The Trump administration's justification for blowing up suspected drug traffickers off the Venezuelan coast has been clear and consistent: These people aren't just criminals; they're "narco-terrorists" smuggling a "deadly weapon poisoning Americans" at the behest of terrorist organizations.

"We take them out," President Donald Trump told the nation's three- and four-star generals and admirals last month. "Every boat kills 25,000 on average — some people say more. You see these boats, they're stacked up with bags of white powder that's mostly fentanyl and other drugs, too."

Claiming the power to summarily kill traffickers as though they're enemy troops, Trump has authorized the U.S. military to strike at least six speedboats the administration has deemed suspicious, killing dozens of people since the beginning of September. At least half of the strikes and 21 of the killings, locals say, have transpired in the waters between Venezuela and Trinidad and Tobago — nations so close that on clear days they're within sight of each other.

But records and interviews with 20 people familiar with the route or the strikes, including current and former U.S. and international officials, contradict the administration's claims. The passage, they said, is not ordinarily used to traffic synthetic opioids such as fentanyl, present in 69 percent of drug overdose deaths last year. Nor are the drugs typically headed for the United States.

SEE **VENEZUELA** ON **A14**

Demolition underway in White House ballroom project



OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST

Despite President Donald Trump's pledge that construction of a ballroom at the White House would not "interfere" with the existing building, crews began tearing down part of the East Wing on Monday. **Story, A2**

Top colleges prove resistant to White House deal

BY **SUSAN SVRLUGA**
AND **EMILY DAVIES**

Despite strong pressure from the Trump administration, including a call with the White House on Friday, colleges and universities are largely rejecting the president's offer of preferential treatment for funding in ex-

change for compliance with his ideological priorities.

Six of nine universities offered the deal earlier this month had publicly said no to the White House request by Monday's deadline for responses.

On Monday, the University of Arizona and Vanderbilt University did not accept the deal, but said

they were open to more discussion.

The administration has said it is seeking to make sure the country's schools are merit-based, but many universities and higher education advocates said the White House's proposed agreement would undermine the merit-based process used to award re-

search grants.

The University of Arizona, said its leaders had not agreed to the terms that had been offered, but pledged to collaborate with the federal government, submitting a Statement of Principles to the Department of Education. Suresh Garimella, the university's president, SEE **COLLEGES** ON **A8**

Trump can send Guard to Portland

APPEALS PANEL SAYS IT'S LIKELY LAWFUL

Surge was ordered over protests at ICE facility

BY **MARK BERMAN**

A federal appeals court Monday said President Donald Trump could deploy the National Guard to Portland, Oregon, blocking a judge's ruling that prohibited his administration from sending troops into the city.

The decision from a divided three-judge panel with the U.S. Court of Appeals for the 9th Circuit authorizes, for now, Trump's efforts to place the military in Oregon's largest city, one of several places where he has sent troops or vowed to do so, including Los Angeles, Chicago and D.C.

In an order released Monday afternoon, a 2-1 majority on the panel said it was likely that Trump acted lawfully in federalizing the National Guard during protests in Portland over immigration enforcement. The order said the judge who blocked Trump from deploying troops there "accorded no deference to the President's determination that he could not execute federal laws with regular forces."

Trump's statements about deploying troops have prompted intense opposition from many state and local leaders. Some have gone to court to challenge such actions, accusing the administration of violating the law and inflaming situations in their communities.

A federal judge in Chicago has blocked Trump's push to deploy troops in Illinois, saying she found a "lack of credibility" in federal officials' contentions in that case. The Trump administration SEE **PORTLAND** ON **A2**

In AI race, long hours become a way of life

BY **DANIELLE ABRIL**

SAN FRANCISCO — Magnus Müller works around-the-clock, including Saturdays and Sundays. Sometimes that might mean starting at 7 a.m. until he goes to sleep at midnight or 1 a.m. The co-founder and CEO of the AI start-up Browser Use lives with five others in a co-living space known as a "hacker house" in San Francisco's upscale Marina neighborhood. This living situation allows his team to convene around a whiteboard at 1 a.m. to work out new ideas for AI agents.

Müller and his team work "996," a term popularized in China that refers to a rigid work schedule in which people work from 9 a.m. to 9 p.m., six days a week. Müller said his company doesn't keep track of each person's working time, and he regularly takes breaks to do other things such as walk through the woods to clear his mind. He wants the start-up to hire people "addicted" to work.

"Most of the staff people count as work I don't," the 24-year-old said. "It's like playing video SEE **996** ON **A9**



NIHARIKA KULKARNI/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Lighting up the night

Women carry diyas, or traditional oil lamps, at Shri Swaminarayan Temple during celebrations to mark Diwali, the Hindu festival of lights, in Varanasi, India, on Monday. **More photos, A16**

Zelensky told by Trump to cede land to Russia

Ukrainian leader seeking European support after tense meeting in U.S.

BY **ELLEN FRANCIS,**
CATHERINE BELTON
AND **DAVID L. STERN**

BRUSSELS — Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky is rallying the support of his European partners after a bruising meeting with President Donald Trump, in which he was told to make concessions to end the war or risk facing destruction at the hands of Russia.

In a tense meeting at the White House on Friday, Trump tossed aside maps of the front line and

urged Kyiv to concede its entire Donbas region to Russia to clinch a deal, according to people familiar with the exchange who spoke on the condition of anonymity to share details of sensitive diplomacy.

"He said [Russian President Vladimir] Putin will destroy you if you don't agree now," one of the people said. "Zelensky had his maps and everything, and he was explaining it to him, but [Trump] wanted nothing to do with it."

Trump listened but was not responsive to the Ukrainian message, the person said. "It was pretty much like, 'No, look, guys, you can't possibly win back any territory. ... There is nothing we can do to save you. You should try to give diplomacy another chance.'" SEE **UKRAINE** ON **A13**

Whistleblower says Social Security needs to prove data is safe

BY **MERYL KORNFELD**
AND **HANNAH NATANSON**

Charles Borges, then chief data officer for the vast Social Security Administration, was alarmed this past summer when he learned that members of Elon Musk's U.S. DOGE Service had copied a main-

frame database containing the personal information of hundreds of millions of Americans, including names, birthdays, addresses and more.

The discovery prompted Borges to file a whistleblower complaint in August, telling Congress and the Office of Special Counsel

that the cloud server where the database was uploaded had little oversight and was vulnerable to attacks by bad actors.

The result: He said the Trump administration's reaction to his complaint caused him to feel isolated and subject to a hostile work environment, prompting him to

resign and give up a decades-long government career and dream job.

Social Security officials insist there has been no breach or security risk, but Borges and other current and former employees say they have concerns about the access that DOGE personnel had

to the data and their efforts to move and manipulate it in ways the agency had never seen before. Even the senior official who granted the Musk team broad access to agency data is now warning that DOGE — short for the Department of Government SEE **WHISTLEBLOWER** ON **A22**

IN THE NEWS

Internet disruptions An Amazon Web Services outage caused problems for apps including Zoom, Pinterest and Slack. **A17**

Attack on former DOGE staffer More teens were charged for their alleged roles in the attempted carjacking of an Elon Musk protégé that preceded the crackdown on D.C. **B13**

THE NATION

The Marines opened a probe into how an artillery shell exploded over a highway in California. **A2**
Lawyers for former FBI director James B. Comey argued the case against him is vindictive. **A4**

THE WORLD

Questions continued to swirl over the brazen heist of precious stones at the Louvre. **A11**
The Trump administration ramped up efforts to bolster the shaky ceasefire in Gaza. **A13**

THE ECONOMY

Most Americans don't have a "quality job," according to a new study, which also outlines five metrics for assessing such a role. **A17**
China's economy grew at its slowest pace in a year during the third quarter, highlighting the bite of the trade war. **A18**

STYLE

In Arena Stage's "Fremont Ave.," three generations bicker over games of spades while building the future. **B1**

SPORTS

Jayden Daniels avoided a major injury, but the Commanders quarterback's status for Week 8 is uncertain. **B7**

THE REGION

A driver who crashed into a tent in a front yard in Maryland, killing one person and injuring 13, was driving in reverse, police said. **B13**
The Scooby Doo Mansion, a group house in D.C., became an arts hub as well. But its future is uncertain. **B13**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A17
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B15
OPINION PAGES.....A20
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A11

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54376

